ASSIGNMENT 1

TITLE: NAVIGATING THE SCIENCE-SOCIETY NEXUS: SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY AND SOCIETY IN POST-COLONIAL INDIA THROUGH THE LENS OF ISLAND PERIPHERIES

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ABSTRACT

This essay examines the evolution of Science, Technology and Society (STS) frameworks in post-independence India through the critical lens of island peripheries, specifically the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Drawing on lived experiences and contextual analysis, the essay interrogates how India's institutional architectures of knowledge production, conceptualized through the triple helix model (university-industry-government) and the aspirational quadruple helix model (adding civil society), systematically exclude indigenous knowledge systems, marginalize peripheral regions, and concentrate technological benefits in metropolitan centers. The analysis reveals critical gaps in current STS frameworks- the epistemic marginalization of traditional knowledge despite policy rhetoric, infrastructure deficits that create unequal access to healthcare, education, and technology, weak industry-academia linkages limiting innovation translation, and the underdeveloped integration of civil society into knowledge production and governance. By foregrounding peripheral perspectives and lived realities from remote island communities, including challenges of ferry-dependent connectivity, diesel-dependent electricity systems, and tribal knowledge exclusion from development planning, the essay demonstrates how Nehru's visionary post-independence STS legacy has both achieved remarkable institutional capacity and simultaneously perpetuated colonial-era patterns of center-periphery domination. The essay concludes that genuine progress toward inclusive STS frameworks requires institutionalizing knowledge co-production, prioritizing equitable infrastructure development, restructuring R&D funding for peripheral regions, and fundamentally reimagining whose knowledge counts and whose communities participate in shaping India's technological future.

Keywords: Science, Technology and Society (STS), Post-colonial India, Triple Helix, Quadruple Helix, Indigenous Knowledge Systems, Peripheral Development, Knowledge Co-production, Epistemic Justice

NAVIGATING THE SCIENCE-SOCIETY NEXUS: SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY AND SOCIETY IN POST-COLONIAL INDIA THROUGH THE LENS OF ISLAND PERIPHERIES

Living in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands offers a unique vantage point to critically examine the evolution of Science, Technology and Society (STS) frameworks in post-independence India. As I board the government ferry from Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram), often the only reliable connection between our scattered island communities, I am reminded daily of how the promises of scientific progress and technological advancement remain unevenly distributed across India's geographical and social landscape. This essay interrogates the trajectories of STS development in post-colonial India, examining the institutional architectures of knowledge production through the triple and quadruple helix models, while foregrounding the lived realities of communities in remote regions like these islands. Through this analysis, critical gaps emerge in how indigenous knowledge systems, regional infrastructure deficits, and community participation are integrated, or more accurately, excluded from mainstream science and technology policy frameworks.

Science, Technology and Society: What does it mean?

Science, Technology and Society (STS) constitutes an interdisciplinary field that examines the creation, development, and deployment of scientific knowledge and technological systems within their broader social, cultural, political, and economic contexts. Unlike traditional approaches that treat science as value-neutral or technology as socially inert, STS scholarship recognizes these domains as fundamentally shaped by, and shaping, societal structures, power relations, and cultural norms. The field draws from anthropology, history, political science, sociology, and philosophy to understand how scientific progress influences society and how societal factors conversely influence the direction and priorities of scientific research and technological innovation.

The essence of STS analysis lies in rejecting the linear model of innovation that positioned science as a purely intellectual pursuit disconnected from social contexts. Instead, contemporary STS frameworks acknowledge that science emerges through complex interactions between researchers, funding bodies, policy frameworks, industry interests, and ultimately, societies that benefit from or are harmed by scientific advancements. This conceptual shift proves particularly important in post-colonial contexts like India, where science and technology are not merely tools for solving technical problems, but instruments intertwined with national identity, economic development, resource distribution, and historical experiences of domination and subordination.

Central to contemporary STS analysis are collaboration models that conceptualize the relationships between key institutional actors in knowledge production. The **triple helix model** of innovation emphasizes constant interactions between three institutional spheres: universities and academia (providing knowledge and research), industry (focusing on commercial production and deployment), and government (creating regulatory frameworks and market environments to foster economic and social development). This model, which evolved from earlier linear conceptions of innovation, recognizes that modern innovation systems require dynamic, iterative exchanges across these three domains. In advanced innovation ecosystems like Silicon Valley, this model has proven remarkably successful, with government

providing concessional land and tax benefits, universities generating cutting-edge research and talent, and industry translating innovations into commercial products.

The theoretical elegance of the triple helix, however, masks a fundamental issue: it operates within elite institutional spaces, privileging formalized R&D, credentialed expertise, and market-driven innovation. The **quadruple helix model** extends this framework by incorporating a 4th crucial actor: civil society, including communities, NGOs, social enterprises, and citizen groups. This addition shifts the focus from purely economic innovation toward user-driven, socially embedded innovation that addresses broader societal challenges. The quadruple helix emphasizes democratic knowledge production, where civil society actors are not merely passive recipients of technological solutions but active participants in defining problems, shaping research agendas, and co-creating innovations. This model has particular relevance for contexts like India, where grassroots innovations, traditional knowledge systems, and community-based solutions coexist, often in tension, with formal scientific and technological institutions.

Building the Architecture of Scientific Modernity

The trajectory of science and technology in post-independence India was fundamentally shaped by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's visionary governance and his explicit conceptualization of science as a cornerstone of national development and modernity. Emerging from nearly 2 centuries of colonial extraction and technological dependence, independent India faced the dual challenge of building scientific capacity from a severely depleted base while simultaneously addressing urgent developmental needs including food security, industrial growth, and strategic autonomy. Nehru's governance established a comprehensive framework for scientific and technological development that privileged state-led institution building, centralized planning, and the cultivation of an elite scientific community.

Nehru's conceptualization of science extended beyond technical applications to encompass a philosophical worldview. His articulation of **"scientific temper"**, a term he coined in 1946 and elaborated in *The Discovery of India*, defined science as "the scientific approach, the adventurous and yet critical temper of science, the search for truth and new knowledge, the refusal to accept anything without testing and trial, the capacity to change previous conclusions in the face of new evidence". For Nehru, science represented not merely a collection of technical techniques but a method of thinking applicable to all spheres of life, capable of liberating people from superstition, dogma, and prejudice. In his 1954 address at the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, he articulated the link between scientific investment and national empowerment: "If we wish to empower our country, which is now independent, we have to create a strong base, so we can learn the basics. This may not show immediate results but finally result in the uplift of the country". This vision transcended economic instrumentalism. Nehru envisioned science as fundamental to India's democratic, secular modernity, addressing not only material poverty but intellectual and social backwardness.

The institutional foundations laid in this period remain central to India's scientific infrastructure today. The establishment of the Indian Institutes of Technology, inaugurated in 1951 at Kharagpur by then Education Minister Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, created world-class centers for technical education explicitly modelled on international best practices but adapted to Indian conditions. Five IITs were subsequently established across the country's breadth on the recommendation of the Sircar Committee, creating a distributed network of elite technical

institutions. The Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), which came into operation in 1942 and expanded dramatically post-independence, established a network of national laboratories spanning remarkably diverse domains: the National Chemical Laboratory, National Physical Laboratory, Central Fuel Research Institute, National Metallurgical Laboratory, Institute for Microbial Technology, and numerous others. CSIR's mandate combined fundamental research with industrial application, positioning it as a bridge between academic inquiry and commercial production. These institutions, along with the Indian Institute of Science in Bangalore, Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, and Bhabha Atomic Research Centre, formed the backbone of India's scientific establishment.

The **1958 Scientific Policy Resolution**, tabled by Nehru in Parliament, marked a watershed in articulating the role of science in national development, declaring that India's future would be shaped by success in cultivating science and scientific research across all domains. This policy framework emphasized self-reliance in strategic sectors, the development of indigenous technological capabilities, and the integration of scientific planning with economic development. The resolution declared: "The dominating feature of contemporary world is the intense cultivation of science on a large scale, and its application to meet a country's requirements". Subsequent decades witnessed remarkable achievements: the establishment of space research capabilities through ISRO, nuclear energy development, advances in agricultural sciences culminating in the Green Revolution, and the growth of pharmaceutical and chemical industries.

The **Green Revolution**, introduced in the late 1960s under then Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, exemplifies both the transformative potential and inherent limitations of the post-independence STS model. Facing severe food shortages and dependence on grain imports, India adopted a package of agricultural technologies including high-yielding variety seeds, chemical fertilizers, mechanization, and expanded irrigation infrastructure. The revolution succeeded dramatically in wheat production, with yields increasing more than threefold between 1967-68 and 2003-04, transforming India from a food-deficit nation requiring imports to one achieving self-sufficiency and building buffer stocks. However, this success was geographically concentrated in regions with existing infrastructure, primarily Punjab, Haryana, and Western Uttar Pradesh, and came with significant environmental and social costs including soil degradation, groundwater depletion, reduced biodiversity, and the marginalization of traditional farming practices and indigenous seed varieties. The Green Revolution exemplifies a critical pattern in post-independence STS, technology transfer without social and environmental differentiation, driven by centralized state planning rather than participatory processes or indigenous knowledge incorporation.

What the Architecture Conceals

The Marginalization of Indigenous Knowledge Systems

Despite India's rich heritage of traditional knowledge spanning medicine, agriculture, astronomy, metallurgy, and ecological management, post-colonial science policy has systematically privileged Western scientific paradigms while treating indigenous knowledge systems as archaic, pre-scientific, or suitable only for documentation and preservation rather than active integration. This epistemic hierarchy, inherited from colonial educational and institutional structures, continues to shape research priorities, funding allocation, and institutional prestige. The consequences are particularly visible in domains like forestry, where

tribal and indigenous communities possess sophisticated, place-based ecological knowledge developed over millennia, including practices of sustainable harvesting, sacred grove conservation, seasonal use patterns, and biodiversity management.

The challenge of integrating indigenous knowledge extends beyond technical or logistical barriers to fundamental epistemological tensions. The **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** has, for the first time, explicitly incorporated indigenous knowledge system integration into higher education, establishing an Innovative Cell for Indian Knowledge Systems at AICTE, with more than 8,000 higher education institutions adopting Indian understanding systems into their curricula. However, this integration effort reveals deep complexities. As scholars note, "*integration*" of knowledge systems requires critical examination of whose knowledge gets integrated, in whose institutional frameworks, for whose benefit. The Ministry of AYUSH's promotion of Hindu (Vedic) knowledge as representative of Indian traditional knowledge, while excluding thousands of indigenous and tribal communities practicing evidence-based science for millennia, illustrates how integration efforts can reproduce historical marginalization even while ostensibly celebrating traditional knowledge. Furthermore, the rigorous methodological translation of experiential, oral, place-based knowledge systems into formal academic curricula remains inadequately theorized and methodologically under-developed.

The **Forest Rights Act of 2006**, while landmark legislation recognizing the rights of forest-dwelling communities to land and resources, reveals the tensions in integrating traditional knowledge with formal forest management. Despite provisions for community forest resource management and the recognition of traditional practices, implementation remains patchy, with forest departments often resistant to ceding authority, inadequate awareness among communities and officials, and systematic undervaluation of indigenous ecological knowledge relative to scientific forestry. The act's implementation architecture, requiring coordination among tribal, revenue, and forest departments through district and sub-district level committees, has faced challenges in many regions, though states like Maharashtra's Gadchiroli district and Kerala's Thrissur district have demonstrated more successful participatory approaches. The gap between legislative recognition and institutional practice reflects deeper challenges: the dominance of scientific forestry training in forest department personnel, the absence of equivalent professional recognition for indigenous forest managers, and the power asymmetries between educated bureaucrats and rural knowledge-holders.

In my own context of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, this marginalization is acutely visible. The **Shompen** and **Nicobarese** tribal communities, along with other particularly vulnerable tribal groups including the Onge, Andamanese, Jarawa, and Great Andamanese, possess intricate knowledge of island ecosystems, sustainable resource use, traditional medicine, and climate adaptation strategies. Yet the proposed Great Nicobar Island development project, a Rs 72,000 crore infrastructure initiative including an international transshipment port, greenfield airport, and township, has proceeded with minimal meaningful consultation with these communities, inadequate social impact assessment, and the denotification of 84 km^2 of tribal reserves. The project exemplifies a development paradigm where technological modernization, strategic requirements and economic integration are prioritized over indigenous rights, traditional livelihoods, and ecological sustainability, with tribal knowledge systems dismissed as obstacles to progress rather than valuable resources for contextually appropriate development.

Infrastructure Deficits and the Uneven Geography of Technological Access

The grand narrative of post-independence scientific progress, space missions, nuclear capabilities, IT prowess, obscures profound geographical inequalities in access to basic technological infrastructure. Living in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, I experience daily how remoteness from mainland centers translates into technological marginalization. **Ferry travel remains the primary, and often only, mode of inter-island transport**. Government-operated passenger-cum-cargo vessels form the backbone of connectivity, taking 3 days for a round voyage from Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram) to Diglipur in the north and 7 days to Campbell Bay in the south. These ships, while essential lifelines for islanders, operate on weather-dependent schedules, frequently face cancellations during monsoons, and provide only basic amenities.

For those of us who need to travel between islands for education, healthcare, or employment, the ferry system's limitations structure our lives in fundamental ways. The private ferry operators, Makruzz, Green Ocean, and Nautika, connect tourist destinations like Havelock (Swaraj Dweep) and Neil Island (Shaheed Dweep) to Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram) with relatively efficient 90-minute services. However, these operators do not serve the more remote inhabited islands, and their higher fares remain inaccessible to many local residents. When ferries are cancelled due to rough seas, a regular occurrence particularly during the southwest monsoon, communities can remain isolated for days or weeks, unable to access emergency medical care, continue education, or maintain employment on other islands. This isolation has direct consequences for technological access- students on remote islands cannot attend schools on larger islands, entrepreneurs cannot reliably reach markets, professionals cannot participate in specialized trainings or conferences on the mainland, researchers cannot access institutional resources or collaborate with peers.

The **electricity infrastructure** in the islands further illustrates technological unevenness. The Andaman and Nicobar Island's total power generation capacity stands at approximately 109 MW, with an overwhelming 99 MW (91%) generated through diesel-based power plants spread across 53 facilities on 19 inhabited islands. Only 5.25 MW comes from hydroelectric generation at the Kalpong project (Diglipur), with minimal solar capacity currently operational despite the region's abundant solar potential. This dependence on costly diesel fuel, which must be transported by ship from the mainland, results in both high electricity costs and significant carbon emissions. Power outages are routine, particularly in smaller islands, and many remote settlements continue to lack reliable 24-hour electricity access.

The island administration has planned ambitious renewable energy expansion, including 21 MW of solar projects with battery energy storage systems and eventually 100 MW of solar capacity. However, the phased implementation timeline extends over decades, and logistical challenges, including the high costs of transporting materials to remote islands, the lack of local technical expertise for installation and maintenance, and the difficulty of integrating variable renewable energy into small, isolated island grids, slow progress substantially. The irony is acute- the islands possess exceptional solar resources, and the technological solutions for renewable energy transition are well-established globally, yet the infrastructure remains predominantly diesel-dependent. The gap reflects not technical incapacity but economic rationality in a centralized planning system that privileges mainland concerns and allocates resources accordingly.

Healthcare and Education: The Consequences of Isolation

Healthcare access in the islands reveals how infrastructure limitations intersect with technological capability. While the Union Territory administration operates 3 district hospitals, 1 government medical college, numerous Primary Health Centers with 10 beds each, and Community Health Centers with 40-70 beds, access remains severely constrained by inter-island connectivity. For residents of remote islands like those in the Nicobar group, accessing specialist medical care often requires multiple ferry journeys, potentially taking days, or helicopter evacuation in emergencies, a service available only sporadically depending on weather and helicopter availability. The telemedicine initiative linking GB Pant Hospital in Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram) with specialists on the mainland, launched in 2002, has improved access to consultation, but cannot substitute for hands-on treatment, diagnostic procedures, or surgeries.

Tribal health services illustrate particular vulnerabilities. Although tribal populations constitute only 9.5% of the total population, the administration has allocated approximately 30% of health institutions to tribal areas. However, the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups face severe health challenges, with limited immunity to diseases common among mainland populations, making increased contact through development projects a significant health risk. Medical subcenters at Dugong Creek (Little Andaman) and Strait Island provide services to Onge and Andamanese communities, with dedicated wards in PHCs near the Jarawa Reserve, yet these remain understaffed and under-resourced. When serious health issues arise, tribal patients must be airlifted to Port Blair, a process that depends on weather conditions, helicopter availability, and bureaucratic approvals, factors that have cost lives.

Educational infrastructure similarly reflects the limitations of peripheral status. While the islands boast a literacy rate exceeding 80%, higher than the national average, this masks significant gaps. Most schools offer only primary education, with secondary and higher secondary institutions concentrated in Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram) and a few larger settlements. Students from remote islands face difficult choices- remain on their home islands with limited educational opportunities or relocate to Port Blair (Sri Vijaya Puram) or the mainland for higher education, often at considerable financial cost and significant family separation. Postsecondary institutions remain scarce, with limited options for technical, nursing, or teacher’s training, forcing most students seeking higher education or professional training to relocate to mainland India.

The Helix Gap: How Innovation Models Keep Excluding the Very Communities They're Supposed to Serve

India's innovation system, when analysed through the triple helix framework, reveals significant structural imbalances. **Universities and research institutions** continue to produce substantial research outputs, India ranks among the top countries globally in scientific publications. The IIT system, CSIR laboratories, and other premier research institutions generate considerable intellectual property, with CSIR holding more than 14,000 patents worldwide. Universities have increasingly established IPR cells, technology transfer offices, and incubators to facilitate commercialization. The **2025 Budget allocations**, with Rs 20,000 crore to the Department of Science and Technology for R&D and innovation as part of a larger

Rs 1 lakh crore fund announced for private sector-driven research, signal governmental commitment to strengthening the innovation ecosystem.

However, the **translation of research into commercial innovation** remains weak. Private sector research and development spending in India accounts for only 41% of total R&D expenditure, compared to over 50% in innovation-led economies. Government contributions still dominate at 50% of total R&D spending. This imbalance suggests that the triple helix remains imbalanced, with government and academia generating knowledge but industry failing to adequately engage in translating research into products, services, and economic value. India's minuscule 0.77% share of global biotechnology patents, despite producing large numbers of PhDs, exemplifies this systemic gap in moving from academic achievement to commercially viable innovation.

The **quadruple helix model**, incorporating civil society, remains more aspirational than realized in most Indian contexts. Initiatives like the Smart Village Movement and climate action collaborations demonstrate potential but remain pilot projects rather than institutionalized practice. **Civil society's integration into knowledge production faces multiple barriers**: lack of formal mechanisms for community participation in research priority-setting, inadequate funding channels for community-based research, the devaluation of non-credentialed knowledge within formal scientific institutions, and power asymmetries between elite scientific institutions and marginalized communities.

Toward More Equitable and Contextual STS Frameworks

Post-independence India's science and technology trajectory embodies both remarkable achievements and troubling exclusions. The institutional foundations established under Nehru's visionary leadership created capacity for indigenous technological development. Recent initiatives expanding R&D funding signal continued commitment. Yet viewed from peripheries, geographical, social, and epistemic, exclusions become visible. Indigenous knowledge systems remain marginalized; the triple helix functions weakly with inadequate industry engagement; the quadruple helix of civil society participation remains underdeveloped; and geographical inequalities in technological infrastructure create differentiated life chances.

From the perspective of island peripheries, addressing these challenges requires: institutionalizing genuine knowledge co-production with indigenous communities; prioritizing equitable technological infrastructure development; restructuring R&D funding and institutional support for peripheral regions; and incorporating distributional equity into science and technology evaluation frameworks. The scenario of Science, Technology and Society in post-colonial India remains open to reshaping, requiring recognition of knowledge pluralism, commitment to participatory governance, and the political will to distribute technological benefits more equitably across India's remarkable geographical and cultural diversity.

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